

1. Subjective Relativism

Summary:

Subjective relativism holds that morality is entirely individual-based: an action is morally right if and only if the person performing it believes it to be right. There are no universal moral standards; each individual has authority over their own moral judgments.

When to Use:

This theory can be useful for understanding personal lifestyle choices that primarily affect the individual alone. It acknowledges that sincere, well-intentioned people may disagree about morally complex or personal matters.

When Not to Apply:

Subjective relativism breaks down when applied to actions that cause significant harm to others. Because it lacks objective standards, it cannot meaningfully condemn actions such as murder, theft, or assault if the individual believes their actions are justified.

Example:

A person may believe that consuming alcohol is morally acceptable, while another believes it is wrong; subjective relativism treats both views as equally valid. However, it cannot justify drunk driving, even if the driver personally believes it is acceptable, due to the clear harm imposed on others.

2. Cultural Relativism

Summary:

Cultural relativism argues that moral right and wrong are determined by a society's cultural norms and values. There are no universal moral truths; morality is relative to a particular cultural context.

When to Use:

The theory promotes tolerance and understanding of diverse cultural practices, encouraging individuals to avoid ethnocentric moral judgments.

When Not to Apply:

Cultural relativism is widely criticized for its inability to condemn practices that are widely considered morally wrong, such as genocide or slavery, if they are culturally accepted. It also undermines social reform by treating existing norms as morally authoritative and ignores moral disagreement within cultures.

Example:

Arranged marriages may be considered morally acceptable in some cultures and unacceptable in others, and cultural relativism allows both perspectives to coexist. However, the theory offers no grounds for condemning practices such as human sacrifice if they are culturally approved.

3. Divine Command Theory

Summary:

Divine Command Theory maintains that moral rightness depends on the will or commands of God. An action is morally right if God commands it and ethically wrong if God forbids it.

When to Use:

Within a shared religious framework, this theory provides a clear moral standard and strong motivation for ethical behaviour through divine reward and punishment.

When Not to Apply:

The theory is challenging to apply in a global or secular society with diverse religious beliefs and values. Additionally, the Euthyphro dilemma raises a significant challenge.

Example:

A believer may view charitable giving as morally obligatory because their religious tradition commands it. However, Divine Command Theory offers limited guidance when attempting to establish moral consensus with individuals of different or no religious beliefs.

4. Ethical Egoism

Summary:

Ethical egoism asserts that individuals are motivated to act in their own rational self-interest. An action is morally right if it maximizes benefit for the agent performing it.

When to Use:

The theory emphasizes self-reliance and personal responsibility. In certain economic contexts, individuals pursuing self-interest can indirectly contribute to overall social benefit, such as innovation or job creation.

When Not to Apply:

Ethical egoism fails to resolve conflicts of interest fairly and disregards the well-being of others. It can justify harmful behaviour as long as it benefits the agent and is incompatible with professions that require prioritizing others' welfare, such as healthcare or public service.

Example:

An ethical egoist might argue that paying taxes is only morally required if it benefits them personally. They would deny any moral obligation to help a stranger if doing so offered no personal advantage.

5. Kantianism (Deontology)

Summary:

Kantian ethics suggests that what is right is based on reason and duty, rather than the results. The main rule is the Categorical Imperative, which means you should only act in ways that everyone can follow, and you must treat people as valuable, not just as means to achieve your goals.

When to Use:

Kantianism is especially useful in contexts involving justice, rights, and fairness. It provides a strong foundation for human rights by emphasizing the inherent dignity of all rational agents.

When Not to Apply:

The theory can be overly rigid when moral duties conflict or when strict rule-following leads to harmful outcomes. Kant's claim that lying is always morally wrong, even to save a life, is often cited as a counterintuitive implication.

Example:

Refusing to lie to a murderer about the whereabouts of their intended victim reflects Kant's commitment to absolute moral duties. Exploiting workers solely for profit would also be immoral, as it treats individuals merely as means rather than ends.

6. Act Utilitarianism

Summary:

Act utilitarianism evaluates each action based solely on its consequences. The morally right action is the one that maximizes overall happiness or utility for all those affected.

When to Use:

This theory is well-suited to situations that require cost-benefit analysis, such as public policy or emergency resource allocation, where maximizing overall welfare is the primary objective.

When Not to Apply:

Act utilitarianism can justify morally troubling actions, such as punishing an innocent person if it benefits the majority. It also requires accurately predicting consequences, which is often unrealistic in everyday decision-making.

Example:

During a public health crisis, an act utilitarian might support mandatory quarantines that restrict individual freedoms if doing so saves a large number of lives and maximizes overall well-being.

7. Rule Utilitarianism

Summary:

Rule utilitarianism holds that an action is morally right if it follows a rule whose general acceptance would maximize overall utility. The focus is on the long-term consequences of adopting moral rules rather than individual actions.

When to Use:

This approach helps avoid some injustices associated with act utilitarianism by supporting rules that promote trust, fairness, and social stability.

When Not to Apply:

Critics argue that rule utilitarianism can resemble rigid deontology (follow rules), potentially preventing morally optimal outcomes in exceptional cases where breaking a rule would produce greater overall good.

Example:

A rule utilitarian would endorse the rule “do not steal” because widespread adherence promotes trust and security, even if stealing in a specific instance might produce more immediate good.

8. Social Contract Theory

Summary:

Social Contract Theory explains morality and political obligation as arising from an implicit or explicit agreement among rational individuals. People accept certain rules in exchange for the benefits of social order, security, and cooperation.

When to Use:

The theory is useful for understanding the justification of laws, rights, and civic duties, particularly in democratic societies where legitimacy depends on mutual agreement and consent.

When Not to Apply:

It struggles to account for the moral status of individuals who cannot participate in the contract, such as animals or infants, and those with limited bargaining power, such as marginalized groups.

Example:

The moral rule against theft is justified by mutual agreement: individuals refrain from stealing with the expectation that others will do the same, benefiting everyone involved.

9. Virtue Ethics

Summary:

Virtue ethics focuses on moral character rather than rules or consequences. It emphasizes cultivating virtues such as honesty, courage, and compassion to achieve a flourishing life (called eudaimonia).

When to Use:

This theory is particularly valuable in personal moral development and professions where character and judgment are central, such as medicine, education, and leadership.

When Not to Apply:

Virtue ethics can be vague when addressing specific moral dilemmas or large-scale policy decisions, especially when virtues conflict or guidance is needed immediately.

Example:

Rather than asking which rule applies or which outcome maximizes utility, a virtue ethicist asks what an honest or compassionate person would do in the situation, emphasizing moral character and habitual action.